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# THA 111: Introduction to Drama and Theatre in the World

The concepts and vocabularies you need before every other theatre course

THEATRE & FILM

## Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 100L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

**Written for students, by students.**

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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# Why this pack exists

This course exists to stop you using 'drama', 'theatre', 'performance' and 'play' as if they mean the same thing. The pack sets out the working distinctions, traces the move from ritual to built theatres, and gives you a vocabulary for discussing any performance tradition in the world.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

## What you will be able to do

- Distinguish drama as text from theatre as performance event.
- Trace the shift from ritual and festival performance to purpose-built theatre buildings.
- Identify the social conventions that shape performance in different periods.
- Use genre and structural terms accurately in written answers.

## How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

## Four terms that are not synonyms

Precise vocabulary earns marks and prevents confused essays.

- Drama: the written or composed work, its structure, character and dialogue.
- Theatre: the collaborative event, including performers, space, audience and technology.
- Performance: the broader category of staged human action, including dance and ritual.
- Play: usually a dramatic text; a production is one realisation of it.
- Text and production can differ sharply: a director's choices are an interpretation, not a copy.

## From ritual to theatre house

The institution of theatre grew out of communal performance and accumulated its own conventions.

- Greek festival theatre: civic competition, masks, chorus and open-air amphitheatre.
- Roman spectacle: larger structures, entertainment politics and a shift in audience composition.
- Medieval religious drama: pageant wagons, guild cycles and church calendar.
- Asian traditions: Noh, Kabuki and Sanskrit theatre developed their own conventions rather than following Europe.
- African festival theatre retained participatory structures that European proscenium theatre reduced.
- Each built form encodes a social relation between performer and audience.

> **The proscenium is an argument**
> A proscenium arch separates performers from spectators. That separation is a historical choice, not a neutral default, and it changes what performance can do.

## Talking about structure and genre

Use these terms with a definition and an example.

- Plot, character, thought, diction, song and spectacle: Aristotle's six elements, still useful as an analysis checklist.
- Tragedy, comedy, tragicomedy, farce, satire and melodrama: know the conventions that define each.
- Conflict, complication, climax and resolution: describe structure rather than retelling plot.
- Dramatic irony: the audience knows what a character does not.
- Convention: an agreed shorthand the audience accepts, from soliloquy to puppetry.

## Text, performance and the gap between them

A play script is an incomplete document. It records dialogue and some stage directions, but it leaves casting, tempo, spatial arrangement, lighting, sound and the audience relationship to a production. Two directors staging the same script can produce events that feel unrelated.

This is why "the play" is ambiguous. Drama is the composed work; theatre is an event that exists only while it is happening. When an exam asks you to discuss a play, check which object it means: the text, a specific production, or the idea of the work across productions. Confusing the three produces answers that drift between literary analysis and reviewing.

A useful habit is to separate three questions. What does the text require? What did this production choose? What did those choices do to the meaning? Answering only the first is a literature answer, not a theatre answer.

## The six elements and what they are for

Aristotle's six elements - plot, character, thought, diction, song and spectacle - are usually memorised and never used. Used properly, they are a checklist for explaining how a play produces its effect, ordered roughly from the most to the least essential in his account.

Plot here means the arrangement of incidents, not the story as chronology. Character means the moral and dramatic function a figure serves. Thought is the reasoning and themes articulated by the action. Diction is the verbal medium, including imagery and rhythm. Song covers the musical and choral dimension. Spectacle is everything seen: design, costume, staging.

For any play on your course, work through the six and rank them for that specific text. In a densely plotted tragedy, plot dominates; in a play built on argument, thought does; in a masque-like spectacle, the ranking inverts. The ranking is the analysis.

> **Say "arrangement", not "story"**
> If you can swap two scenes without changing the play, you have identified where the plot work actually happens. Try it on any set text.

## From ritual and festival to purpose-built theatre

The standard history moves from communal ritual to civic festival to professional theatre to the proscenium stage, but it is not a story of improvement. Each step changes who the audience is and what the audience is for.

In a civic festival, the audience is a citizen body, and attendance is partly a civic duty. In commercial theatre, the audience is a paying public, and repertory responds to taste. In proscenium theatre, the audience is seated in darkness, addressed by an illusion that pretends they are not there. Each structure makes some kinds of performance easy and others difficult.

African festival traditions retained participatory structures that proscenium theatre had reduced, which is why the historical sequence is not a single line of development. The comparison question is not "which is more advanced" but "what does each arrangement allow the audience to do".

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

# Session record: THA 111

*2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026*

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

## 2018 — Archived course description — ARCHIVED

- THA 111 Introduction to Drama and Theatre in the World described as an introduction to the nature of drama and theatre
- Emphasis on non-written traditions, festivals and rituals up to the institution of built stages and arenas
- Attention to the social conventions operating in those venues that create both literature and performance

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

## 2019 — Archived programme listing — ARCHIVED

- THA 111 Introduction to Drama and Theatre in the World, 3 credits, first semester
- Listed beside THA 101, 131, 151, 153 and 161 in the same semester
- Total first-semester load shown as 24 credits including GST courses

*What changed: The 2019 listing keeps THA 111 as a core 100-level first-semester course with no title change.*

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

## 2025/2026 — Compiled working map — CURRENT WORKING MAP

- THA 111 remains the conceptual gateway to the programme in the compiled 2025/2026 map
- Expect comparative examples from African, Asian and European traditions rather than a Europe-only survey
- Confirm the current credit value, since 100-level loads were revised in later listings

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

*Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.*

WORKED EXAMPLES

# Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

## 1. Distinguishing the four terms in an exam sentence

A question asks: "Drama is not theatre." Discuss. Here is how to build an answer that uses all four terms precisely.

1. Define drama as the composed structure of action and speech, whether written or remembered.
2. Define theatre as the live event in which performers, space, audience and technology produce meaning together.
3. Define performance as the wider category of staged human action, including dance, ritual and sport-like spectacle.
4. Define play as a dramatic text, and production as one realisation of it.
5. Show a case where the distinction matters: a script that reads as comedy but is staged as tragedy, and what that reveals about where meaning lives.
6. Conclude with a position: drama is the score, theatre is the performance, and neither is the whole work.

> **What to carry forward**
> Four definitions plus one worked case beats a page of general statements about the magic of the stage.

## 2. Reading a stage direction as evidence

A script says: "(A long silence. The lamp gutters.)" What can you legitimately claim from this?

1. Identify what the direction fixes: duration marked as significant, and a dependency on a practical light source on stage.
2. State the production requirements it creates: a working lamp, control over dimming or flame effect, and actors able to hold a silence.
3. State the interpretive possibilities it opens: crisis, decision, time passing, or social decay, depending on context.
4. Distinguish evidence from inference: the silence is in the text; "the marriage is over" is your reading and must be argued.
5. Explain how a director's choice would change the meaning: a longer silence with the lamp left burning gives a different scene from one played in darkness.

> **What to carry forward**
> Stage directions are production constraints. Read them as instructions to a company, not as decoration.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

# Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

## Q1. Explain, with examples, the difference between drama and theatre, and why the distinction matters for a student of theatre.

*20 marks*

1. Define both terms, and add performance and production for completeness.
2. Use one script and describe what the text fixes and what it leaves open.
3. Describe one production decision (casting, space, tempo) and show how it changed meaning.
4. Explain the disciplinary consequence: literary analysis answers "what does the text mean", theatre analysis answers "how did this event produce meaning".
5. Note the limit case: devised and festival theatre may have no fixed dramatic text at all, which tests your definitions.
6. Conclude with a working rule for your own essays.

> **Where marks are lost**
> Using "drama" and "theatre" interchangeably after defining them carefully. Consistency is marked.

## Q2. Discuss the claim that Greek theatre was a civic institution rather than entertainment.

*15 marks*

1. Describe the festival of Dionysus: competition, choregos funding, citizen audience, prizes.
2. Show the civic dimension: subject matter debated in public, attendance as participation in the polis, the chorus as a civic voice.
3. Acknowledge the entertainment dimension: spectacle, comedy competitions, audience reaction.
4. Distinguish the two claims rather than choosing one: civic function and popular appeal coexisted.
5. Conclude with what the case teaches about any theatre that claims a public role.

## Q3. How did the proscenium arch change what theatre could do?

*15 marks*

1. Describe the architectural change: a framed stage, a separated auditorium, controlled sightlines.
2. Explain the new possibilities: illusionistic scenery, lighting control, the fourth wall, realistic interior drama.
3. Explain what it made harder: direct address, audience participation, fluid multiple locations.
4. Compare with one non-proscenium form - festival, arena or thrust stage - on a specific effect.
5. Conclude that staging shapes dramaturgy: writers began writing for the space they had.

**Where marks are lost**

Treating the proscenium as simply "better theatre". It is a set of affordances, not a rank.

REFERENCE

# Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Drama. The composed structure of action and speech in a play, considered apart from any single production.

Theatre. The live collaborative event in which performers, audience, space and technology produce meaning together.

Performance. The broader category of staged human action, including dance, ritual and spectacle beyond scripted drama.

Production. One particular realisation of a dramatic text by a specific company, in a specific space, on specific dates.

Convention. An agreed shorthand that an audience accepts, such as the soliloquy or a bare stage standing for a forest.

Dramatic irony. A gap between what the audience knows and what a character knows, used to produce tension or comedy.

Catharsis. Aristotle's term for the purgation or clarification of pity and fear produced by tragedy.

Chorus. A group performer in classical drama that comments, questions and embodies communal judgement.

Proscenium arch. A structural frame separating stage from auditorium, supporting illusionistic staging.

Thrust stage. A stage projecting into the auditorium so the audience surrounds it on three sides.

Fourth wall. The imagined boundary between a realistic stage world and its audience, which the actors behave as if unaware of.

Devised theatre. Performance created collaboratively by a company rather than from a pre-existing script.

## Your four-week plan

### Week 1 - Terms

Precision with vocabulary.

- Write the four definitions from memory.
- Take one play and identify its genre conventions.
- Practise using each term in a sentence about a play.

### Week 2 - Structures

Aristotle in use.

- Rank the six elements for two different plays and justify the ranking.
- Map one play into acts, units and turning points.
- Explain one stage direction as a production constraint.

### Week 3 - History

Forms and their affordances.

- Draw a timeline from Greek festival to proscenium.
- Compare two theatre spaces on audience role.

- Write one paragraph on a non-European tradition.

Week 4 - Exam

Timed writing.

- Answer the drama/theatre question in 35 minutes.
- Check every definition is used consistently.
- Redo the conclusion so it states a position.

## Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Aristotle - Poetics (any modern translation with notes; read the sections on plot and character).
- Any standard introduction to theatre history covering Greek, medieval and Renaissance practice.
- Your departmental reading list for THA 111 - editions differ, so cite the one you used.
- One play from your course, read twice: once for story, once for staging demands.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

## Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Distinguish drama from theatre in one sentence each.

Answer: Drama is the composed work with its structure and dialogue; theatre is the live collaborative event that stages it before an audience.

2. Why is the proscenium arch historically significant?

Answer: It institutionalised a clear separation between performers and audience, shaping realistic illusion and a passive spectator role.

3. What does dramatic irony require?

Answer: A gap between what the audience knows and what a character knows, used to create tension or humour.

4. Name Aristotle's six elements of drama.

Answer: Plot, character, thought, diction, song and spectacle.

5. Give one example of a theatrical convention and explain what it asks the audience to accept.

Answer: The soliloquy asks the audience to accept that a character is speaking their private thoughts aloud while others on stage do not hear.

## Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write definitions of drama, theatre, performance and play.
- [ ] Draw a timeline from Greek festival theatre to the modern stage.
- [ ] Compare two world theatre traditions in a table of conventions.
- [ ] Analyse a short play using Aristotle's six elements.
- [ ] Collect five theatrical conventions with one example each.
- [ ] Write a 250-word answer distinguishing text from production.
- [ ] Learn ten genre terms and match each to a play you know.

## Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

# Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

**Three ideas I can now explain without notes:**

**A question I still cannot answer:**

**For my lecturer or course rep:**

**Next revision action and date:**